Non Omnis Moriar

by Kevin Cochran



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OPEN: CATHOLIC CHURCH FOYER. JUST AFTER SUNDAY MASS.
(FATHER LUCAS is shaking hands with parishioners and visitors.)

HENRY. Father Lucas, wonderful service. Just wonderful.
LUCAS. (*laughs*) Well, thanks, Henry.
HENRY. Listen, I brought a friend with me and I'd love to introduce you. He's in town for the week. Church isn't really his thing, but he's the nicest guy.
LUCAS. I'd love to meet him.
HENRY. Sure let me find him. (*leaves to find him*) Ben? Ben?

(*BEN enters. LUCAS'S face falls.)*

HENRY. Father Lucas, I'd like you to meet…

FLASHBACK: COLLEGE PARTY. 10 YEARS EARLIER
LUCAS and BEN meet. It is love at first sight.

BEN. (*smiles warmly*) Ben.
LUCAS. (*smiles dumbly, as they shake hands*) Lucas.

FLASHFORWARD: CATHOLIC CHURCH FOYER.
(LUCAS and BEN shake hands. It is betrayal and heartbreak and shock at first sight.)

LUCAS. (*struggles*) Nice…To meet you.

INTRO

FLASHBACK: COLLEGE PARTY

LUCAS. I have to go.
BEN. You *have* to? You didn't know this was a gay party?
LUCAS. No. I didn't. I…I just thought it was a party.
BEN. With the theme "no girls allowed"…?
LUCAS. Well, some people say that's the theme of Catholicism.
BEN. You thought it was a Catholic party?
LUCAS. I really should go. (*Long moment. Lucas can't make himself leave. BEN smiles in triumph.*) Sorry.
BEN. So cute.
LUCAS. I'm sorry?
BEN. You don't have to keep apologizing.
LUCAS. No, I didn't hear you. I mean, I thought you said…something.

BEN. Tell me about this (*picks the cross pendant up off LUCAS'S chest*)

LUCAS. It's a cross. I was raised Catholic.

BEN. You were raised Catholic, or you *are* Catholic?

LUCAS. Um, both?

BEN. Then why wear the cross?

LUCAS. I'm going to seminary next year.

BEN. But if you're Catholic – or really any type of Christian – isn't this an incredibly depressing fashion statement?

LUCAS. Ha. I never thought of that. I guess… well, it's a reminder of sacrifice. A symbol. It keeps me connected to a spirit of love and keeps me in comfort.

BEN. Yeah…that's the same reason I wear Calvin Klein's (*shows underwear*).

LUCAS. You're mocking faith or me?

BEN. A little of both.

LUCAS. Mind if I ask why?

BEN. Mind if I ask for your number?

FLASHFORWARD: INSIDE THE CHURCH RECTORY.
(BEN enters nervously.)

LUCAS. Ben?

BEN. I, um, came to apologize about the other day. I really didn't even think about looking at who the priest would be. I mean, I stopped checking years ago…I shouldn't have said that out loud. Sorry… I probably should have called first.

LUCAS. That's not necessary.

BEN. The call or the apology?

LUCAS. …

BEN. (*sigh*) Look, maybe we just need to talk?

LUCAS. Yes. But I'm not sure if here is the right place.

BEN. Why? Because we're in "the big room?"

LUCAS. Yes.

BEN. Afraid your God will throw lightening bolts?

LUCAS. He's not *my* God.

BEN. Well, he's certainly not mine.

LUCAS. I see some thing's never change.

BEN. And some things seem to change completely. Talk about a boy who can alter.

LUCAS. (*shakes his had, but smiles*) Ben.

BEN. Lucas…

LUCAS. Most people call me Father now.

BEN. Well that would just seem dirty coming from me, don't you think?

LUCAS. (*innocently*) Don't gloat.

BEN. Gloat?

LUCAS. Maybe that was the wrong choice of word, but you know what I mean.

BEN. No, I actually don't. Shocking, I know, to not know what the hell you're saying. But…

LUCAS. Please watch you're language.

BEN. Why?

LUCAS. We're in God's house.

BEN. No, we're in a house for God that people built. It's no more holy than a condo on 8th or a barn. After all, that's where Jesus was born.

LUCAS. Jesus wasn't born in a condo on 8th. He was the miracle on 34nd street. No… wait…that was Santa.

BEN. Did you just make a joke?

LUCAS. …maybe.

BEN. You're allowed to do that?

LUCAS. (*joking again*) It'll cost me some Hail Mary's, but yeah.

BEN. …I'm just a little caught off guard. And…I don't know, lots of big feelings.

LUCAS. Yeah, we're sort of used to that in this place.

BEN. So anyway, I'm sorry. I bet you hear that a lot, too.

LUCAS. From myself and others, yes.

FLASHBACK: COLLEGE COFFEE SHOP
(Lucas has been rambling for quite some time.)

BEN. (*spills coffee*) Oops, I'm so sorry.

LUCAS. It's fine. No use crying over spilled latte.

BEN. Guess not. Thanks for hanging out with me, I've had a great time.

LUCAS. Me too. Although, I don't usually talk so much.

BEN. It's alright. I only had to remind you to breath three times. (*Offers him fruit*) Apple?

LUCAS. (*Looks at fruit for a moment*) Ben, can I ask you something?

BEN. You just did.

LUCAS. How did you know you were gay?

BEN. (*shrug*) I think it's the same way you know you believe in God.

LUCAS. (*fiddles with his necklace*) Explain, please.

BEN. I don't know. I guess it's like your faith. It's such a vital part of you.

LUCAS. Think so?

BEN. Yeah, it is. It's like this beautiful force that lights you up. It's like…seeing you at your most alive. That's what it's like for me. Gay isn't just what I am; it's part of who I am. What does your God say about that?

LUCAS. I bet. (*takes off his necklace and puts it in LUCAS'S hand*) He's very happy to have made you. Just the way you are. (*They both look at their hands on one another. A charged moment passes.)*

FLASHFORWARD: INSIDE THE CHURCH RECTORY.

BEN. You haven't told any of them, have you? Your "flock." Nobody knows.

LUCAS. I don't see the relevance.

BEN. You're joking, right? I mean, come on! You're terrified they're going to bring out the fire and brimstone and burn you at the stake, right?

LUCAS. And why would they do that?

BEN. Because you're gay, Lucas!

LUCAS. No. I'm a priest.

BEN. And a priest can't possibly be gay?

LUCAS. I'm not saying that. I'm saying sexual orientation doesn't matter when you're married to the church.

BEN. You can say that with a straight face?

LUCAS. Not a *straight* face, no.

BEN. This is nuts. You're gay and you standing there in the uniform of your own oppressor and you're cracking jokes—

LUCAS. That's really what you think? That I am some raging homophobic cliché, swimming around in self-loathing and hoping God will save me from my base urges?

BEN. Aren't you?

LUCAS. No! There is a difference between letting religion hide you and letting faith define you, Ben.

BEN. Look, hide yourself in whatever church closet you want. What's it to me?

LUCAS. I was always going to seminary. I was always meant for this life.

BEN. You may have always been headed here, but you ran away from me and you know it.

FLASHBACK: COLLEGE CAMPUS

BEN. Hey, wait up. I need a moment of your time, good sir.

LUCAS. I can't right now, I have to go.

BEN. Ok…is everything ok? I feel like you've been avoiding me.

LUCAS. No.

BEN. No, you haven't been avoiding me, or no, everything's not ok.

LUCAS. I don't know.

BEN. What's going on with you?

LUCAS. Ben, I'm really busy and stressed out and I can't give you what you want.

BEN. What I want? What's that?

LUCAS. (*very awkward moment*)…time. A moment of my time. You just said that.

BEN. Oh. Right.

LUCAS. I better leave. It's just…

BEN. Yeah?

LUCAS. Nothing. It's all nothing.

FLASHBACK: BEN'S COLLEGE DORM
(Lucas is drunk and throws a pebble/rock at Ben's window. No sound.)

LUCAS. Dammit. Oh fine. Ben! BEN!

BEN. (*half asleep*) Lucas? What are you doing?

LUCAS. I am throwing pebbles at your window. I could've sworn I hit it a few times.

BEN. The window is open.

LUCAS. That explains it.

BEN. Saint Lucas, are you drunk?

LUCAS. …Maybe.

BEN. Hang on. (*leaves the window*)

LUCAS. (*to himself*) Leave. Leave now. Turn and go, you idiot.

BEN. (*Opens the door*) Hey, come on in.

LUCAS. No.

BEN. It's freezing out here.

LUCAS. I can't stop feeling it.

BEN. You can. Just come inside and thaw out.

LUCAS. No, you don't understand.

BEN. What's going on?

LUCAS. …Nothing. I shouldn't have come here. (*Turns to go. Stumbles. BEN catches him easily. LUCAS clutches him in an embrace. After a tender and charged moment, LUCAS kisses BEN softly, then retreats abruptly.*)

BEN. Lucas, I think I love—

(*LUCAS punches BEN in the face and runs away*.)

FLASHFORWARD: INSIDE THE CHURCH RECTORY.

BEN. Then you just…disappeared. I asked all your friends, I tried to find your folks, I even looked up seminaries and started cold-calling them pretending to be an estates attorney.

LUCAS. I needed to go. Or I wouldn't have left.

BEN. And that would have just been awful, would it? You told me you thought God loved me for being gay, but apparently not you, huh? Needed to cleanse yourself of me and my impurities?

LUCAS. No. I didn't condemn myself to this; I chose it.

BEN. Whatever helps you sleep at night, *Father*.

LUCAS. Why is that so hard for you to understand?

BEN. Because you gave up something real. You gave up something real and sacred and ran away.

LUCAS. I don't see it like that. Wait, that came out wrong. What I meant—

BEN. No, it's fine. I think I finally understand you. (*leaves*)

LUCAS. Ben!

FLASHFORWARD: CATHOLIC CHURCH CONFESSIONAL BOOTH

BEN. Bless me father, for I have sinned.

LUCAS. (*sighs*) Ben.

BEN. I thought this was supposed to be anonymous.

LUCAS. I am glad you came back, let's go—

BEN. I'm just here for confession. And then I'm going.

LUCAS. Ok, but you're not Catholic. Confession won't absolve you of your sins.

BEN. You might be surprised. It might absolve us both. So, how do I do this?

LUCAS. You admit your sins and then you are forgiven and we…we forget.

BEN. Promise?

LUCAS. (*long moment of silence. No one knows what to say.)…*I knew.

BEN. What?

LUCAS. I knew it wasn't a Catholic party. In college. I knew.

BEN. …Yeah. I just…I need to know…are you happy?

LUCAS. I am happy here. I love my work and I love the Church.

BEN. That's…good.

LUCAS. You're wrong if you think you're the reason I left.

BEN. Forgive me, Father… I have loved you every day. Every moment.

LUCAS. No one needs forgiveness for love, Ben. And I promise you, I have never asked for forgiveness for loving you. I have asked for patience, I've asked for strength, I've asked for comfort…because I don't think I've ever loved anything like I loved you. Like I will always love you.

BEN. Always, huh?

LUCAS. Always.

BEN. Couldn't you have lied, just this once?

LUCAS. Some things never change.

BEN. I guess not. But then again, some things have to.

OPEN: CATHOLIC CHURCH

LUCAS. (*LUCAS delivers his sermon while BEN enters, removes the necklace that Lucas gave him years before and sets it down on the pew as Lucas delivers his sermon.)* Friends, Paul said there are many types of love. There is the kind we feel for our friends and community, the passion we feel for our partners and spouses, and then there is the love we feel for God. It is self-donation without concern of cost or reward. Believe me when I say that this is the most challenging kind of love. But no matter the love we feel, or the people we feel it for, it is imperative that we remember that love is a gift and it is a blessing, in all its forms. It is the greatest of all things.